

Treatise on Good Works

The Third Commandment

Martin Luther made the teaching of the Bible about good works much more clear to the average Christian. He teaches that good works are commanded by God but that many Christians misunderstand what they really are.

I. We have now seen how many good works there are in the Second Commandment, which however are not good in themselves, unless they are done in faith and in the assurance of divine favor; and how much we must do, if we take heed to this Commandment alone, and how we, alas! busy ourselves much with other works, which have no agreement at all with it. **Now follows the Third Commandment: "Thou shalt hallow the day of rest."** In the First Commandment is prescribed our heart's attitude toward God in thoughts, in the Second, that of our mouth in words, in **this Third is prescribed our attitude toward God in works**; and it is the first and right table of Moses, on which these three Commandments are written, and they govern man on the right side, namely, in the things which concern God, and in which God has to do with man and man with God, without the mediation of any creature.

- The first three commandments are different from the other commandments because they are focused on what kind of relationship?
- The Sabbath is supposed to be a special day taken to focus on what?

The first works of this Commandment are plain and outward, which we commonly call **worship**, such as going to mass, **praying**, and hearing a **sermon** on holy days. So understood there are very few works in this Commandment; and **these, if they are not done in assurance of and with faith in God's favor, are nothing**, as was said above. Hence it would also be a good thing if there were fewer saint's days, since in our times the works done on them are for the greater part worse than those of the work days, what with loafing, gluttony, and drunkenness, gambling and other evil deeds; and then, the mass and the sermon are listened to without edification, the prayer is spoken without faith. It almost happens that men think it is sufficient that we look on at the mass with our eyes, hear the preaching with our ears, and say the prayers with our mouths. It is all so formal and superficial! We do not think that we might receive something out of the mass into our hearts, learn and remember something out of the preaching, seek, desire and expect something in our prayer.

- Why is it that going to church worship, praying, and listening to the sermon count as nothing if there is no faith in a person's heart?
- What has Luther got against holidays?
- If a person doesn't believe in God would it be better if they went to church or didn't go to church?

II. In the mass it is **necessary that we attend with our hearts also**; and we do **attend**, when we **exercise faith in our hearts**. Here we must repeat the words of Christ, when He institutes the mass and says, "**Take and eat, this is My Body, which is given for you**"; in like manner over the cup, "**Take and drink ye all of it: this is a new, everlasting Testament in My Blood, which is shed for you and for many for the remission of sins. This shall ye do, as oft as ye do it, in remembrance of Me.**" **In these words Christ has made for Himself a memorial** or anniversary, to be daily observed in all Christendom, and has added to it a glorious, rich, great testament, in which no interest, money or temporal possessions are bequeathed and distributed, but the forgiveness of all sins, grace and mercy unto eternal life, that all who come to this memorial shall have the same testament; and then He died, whereby this testament has become permanent and irrevocable. In proof and evidence of which, instead of letter and seal, **He has left with us His own Body and Blood under the bread and wine**.

- What happens when an unbeliever takes part in the Lord's supper? Does it improve that unbeliever's relationship with God?
- What is the reason for taking part in the Lord's supper?
- The next time you take part in communion is the anything you want to do differently?

Here there is need that **a man practice the first works of this Commandment right well, that he doubt not that what Christ has said is true, and consider the testament sure, so that he make not Christ a liar.** For if you are present at mass and do not consider nor believe that here Christ through His testament has bequeathed and given you forgiveness of all your sins, what else is it, than **as if you said: "I do not know or do not believe that it is true that forgiveness of my sins is here bequeathed and given me"**? Oh, how many masses there are in the world at present! but how few who hear them with such faith and benefit! **Most grievously is God provoked to anger thereby.** For this reason also **no one shall or can reap any benefit from the mass except he be in trouble of soul and long for divine mercy,** and desire to be rid of his sins; or, if he have an evil intention, he must be changed during the mass, and come to have a desire for this testament. For this reason in olden times no open sinner was allowed to be present at the mass.

- Do you agree with Luther that God is angry when believers taking communion doubt that their sins are forgiven?
- If God isn't angry how do you think he reacts?
- What would you say to a believer who is struggling to believe in the forgiveness; should they take communion or not take it?

When this faith is rightly present, the heart must be made joyful by the testament, and grow warm and melt in God's love. Then will follow praise and thanksgiving with a pure heart, from which the mass is called in Greek Eucharistia, that is, "thanksgiving," because we praise and thank God for this comforting, rich, blessed testament, just as he gives thanks, praises and is joyful.

- If a believer has faith in Christ, how should they feel when they take part in a communion service?
- What is the best way to show your joy when you take communion?

VII. Again: if no other work were commanded, **would not prayer alone suffice to exercise the whole life of man in faith?** For this work the spiritual estate has been specially established, as indeed in olden times some Fathers prayed day and night. Nay, there is no Christian who does not have time to pray without ceasing. But I mean the spiritual praying, that is: no one is so heavily burdened with his labor, but that if he will he can, while working, **speak with God in his heart, lay before Him his need and that of other men, ask for help, make petition, and in all this exercise and strengthen his faith.**

- If we find that we lack faith when we take communion what would God want us to do about it?

This is what the Lord means, Luke xviii, when He says, "Men ought always to pray, and never cease," although in Matthew He forbids the use of much speaking and long prayers, because of which He rebukes the hypocrites; not because the lengthy prayer of the lips is evil, but because it is not that true prayer which can be made at all times, and without the inner prayer of faith is nothing. For we must also practice the outward prayer in its proper time, especially in the mass, as this Commandment requires, and wherever it is helpful to the inner prayer and faith, whether in the house or in the field, in this work or in that; of which we have no time now to speak more. For this belongs to the Lord's Prayer, in which all petitions and spoken prayer are summed up in brief words.

- When do you pray?
- Are some times better than others?